Friday the 13th: Why Does This Day Scare So Many People?

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Friday, November 13, 2026, is the third and last Friday the 13th of the year. For most people, it is simply the start of the weekend. But for millions of people around the world, it can feel like the unluckiest day of the year. Some even have a name for the fear: **paraskevidekatriaphobia**, the extreme fear of Friday the 13th.

No one knows exactly how the belief began, but several theories point to the number 13. Professor Thomas Fernsler of the University of Delaware notes that 13 gets a bad reputation because it comes right after the number 12, which many people see as complete: 12 months in a year, 12 **zodiac** signs, and 12 **apostles** of Jesus. Because 13 follows that tidy number, it often feels incomplete, and therefore unlucky.

Folklore historian Donald Dossey traces the fear to a **Norse** myth from the Viking era. According to the legend, twelve gods were enjoying a peaceful dinner when Loki, the god of mischief, arrived uninvited and tricked Hodr, the blind god of darkness, into killing Baldr, the god of joy and light. Many Nordic cultures still consider 13 guests at a table unlucky, and in France, some people hire a 14th guest to avoid the number.

According to the Bible, Jesus was **crucified** on a Friday, shortly after the Last Supper, which included 13 people. People who fear the day may feel anything from mild anxiety to full panic.

Surprisingly, the day also affects the United States economy: businesses lose as much as $900 million when people avoid work, travel, or big purchases. Yet a 2008 Dutch study found fewer traffic accidents that day than on other Fridays. For bargain hunters, special discounts might turn the last Friday the 13th of 2026 into your luckiest day yet.

Word Treasure

paraskevidekatriaphobia -- The extreme fear of Friday the 13th.
apostles -- The twelve close followers of Jesus.
zodiac -- The twelve signs used to divide the year in astrology.
Norse -- Relating to the people and old myths of Scandinavia.
crucified -- Put to death by being nailed to a cross.
Folklore -- Traditional stories and beliefs passed down among people.

Background you need

Friday the 13th is a day many people treat as unlucky, and some people feel real fear when it arrives. Much of that fear comes from the number 13, which follows 12, a number many people see as complete because a year has 12 months and there are 12 signs of the zodiac. Old stories added to the fear: a Norse myth tells of a dinner with twelve gods that turned tragic when an uninvited thirteenth guest arrived, and the Bible tells of a Last Supper with thirteen people before Jesus was crucified on a Friday. Over time these stories mixed together, so the day became a symbol of bad luck that can make people nervous or change their plans, even though nothing about the date itself causes bad things to happen.

Break it down

LEAD: Friday, November 13, 2026, is the third and last Friday the 13th of the year; most people treat it as the start of the weekend, but millions of people around the world fear it as the unluckiest day of the year.

THE FEAR:

+- NAME: paraskevidekatriaphobia, the extreme fear of Friday the 13th

+- FEELINGS: people who fear the day may feel anything from mild anxiety to full panic

ORIGINS: No one knows exactly how the belief began, but several theories point to the number 13.

+- THE NUMBER 12: Professor Thomas Fernsler of the University of Delaware says 13 feels incomplete, and therefore unlucky, because it follows 12, which many people see as complete: 12 months in a year, 12 zodiac signs and 12 apostles of Jesus.

+- NORSE MYTH: Folklore historian Donald Dossey traces the fear to a Viking-era myth in which twelve gods were enjoying a peaceful dinner when Loki, the god of mischief, arrived uninvited and tricked Hodr, the blind god of darkness, into killing Baldr, the god of joy and light.

+- THE BIBLE: Jesus was crucified on a Friday, shortly after the Last Supper, which included 13 people.

REAL-WORLD EFFECTS:

+- ECONOMY: Businesses in the United States lose as much as $900 million when people avoid work, travel or big purchases.

+- SAFETY: A 2008 Dutch study found fewer traffic accidents that day than on other Fridays.

+- BARGAINS: For bargain hunters, special discounts might turn the last Friday the 13th of 2026 into the luckiest day yet.

OPEN QUESTION: No one knows exactly how the belief began, so the true origin of the fear remains unsettled.

Why it matters

The fear of Friday the 13th shows how old stories and beliefs can still shape how millions of people feel and act today, even costing businesses as much as $900 million. Understanding where such fears come from helps us tell the difference between superstition and real risk.

Test what you remember

1. How many Friday the 13ths are there in 2026, and which one is November 13?

- (A) The third and last of the year
- (B) The second of three
- (C) The first of four
- (D) The only one

2. What is paraskevidekatriaphobia?

- (A) The extreme fear of Friday the 13th
- (B) A fear of weekends
- (C) A fear of the number 12
- (D) A fear of travelling on Fridays

3. According to Professor Thomas Fernsler, why does the number 13 feel unlucky?

- (A) Because it has two digits
- (B) Because it is a prime number
- (C) Because it comes right after 12, which many people see as complete
- (D) Because it is larger than 10

4. In the Norse myth, who tricked Hodr into killing Baldr?

- (A) Loki
- (B) A 14th guest in France
- (C) Hodr
- (D) Baldr

5. How much money can businesses in the United States lose because of Friday the 13th?

- (A) Nothing at all
- (B) About $9 million
- (C) About $90,000
- (D) As much as $900 million

6. What did a 2008 Dutch study find about Friday the 13th?

- (A) No accidents at all
- (B) Fewer traffic accidents that day than on other Fridays
- (C) The same number of accidents as on other Fridays
- (D) More traffic accidents than on other Fridays

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Professor Thomas Fernsler: The number 13 gets a bad reputation because it follows 12, which many people see as complete.

2. Folklore historian Donald Dossey: The fear traces back to a Norse myth from the Viking era about Loki tricking Hodr into killing Baldr.

3. People who fear Friday the 13th: They see the day as unlucky and may feel anything from mild anxiety to full panic.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):